

Barber Trims Miners, 9-4

By BART RIPP

New Mexico right-hander Bruce Barber likes to walk up to people and ask in a mock-Leslie Caron accent: "Are my feathers green? Does my gown look purple?"

The Lobo and Texas-El Paso baseball teams locked in mortal combat Friday and when the dust had cleared, or at least stopped swirling at the Sports Stadium, Barber turned the Miners a paler shade of orange.

Barber, who may have lost if he'd seen Arizona or Arizona State uni-

forms on the Miners, undressed UTEP, 9-4 in the opener of the three-game series that could decide — ta-DA! trumpets blare — third place in the Western Athletic Conference Southern Division.

A six-run uprising in the second inning won the game for New Mexico, which captured its first league game in seven tries. Aaron Cain, Steve Muccio and Mike Brown each drove in two runs during the brisk game. Shortstop Mike Foote, despite some unsteady baserunning, clubbed three singles and knocked home three runs.

But it was the senior Barber, likened

to the Lobo pitching ace at the beginning of the season, who finally had his day in the sun and dust. Barber pitched seven good innings, spacing 10 Miner hits, and wasn't hit hard after a rocky first inning.

"I was due," understated Barber, who evened his record at 3-3. "I've had a horsefeathers year. I just told myself that I was gonna throw a good ballgame."

"Vince (Lobo Coach Cappelli) started me on a slider and I was finally able to get my breaking pitch over."

Andy Cohen, the 73-year-old Miner coach, didn't make the trip because his wife is ill in El Paso. Andy's equally-spry brother Syd, a mere 70, ran the ballclub.

Trivia buffs will be eager to know that Syd, while employed by the Washington Senators in 1934, was the last American League pitcher to strike out Babe Ruth. Syd also was the last AL pitcher to serve a home run to Ruth.

With those facts in mind, the Lobos and Miners reconvene this afternoon at the Sports Stadium. They'll play a double-header at 1.